



result, 70 percent of black people voted for him in the November election, contributing to his victory.

In 1961, seven black and six white youngsters became known as "Freedom Riders" touring the South together on a bus to protest against the segregation laws. When the bus reached Anniston, Alabama, a mob ambushed it and threw in a firebomb. The Freedom Riders forced their way out but were beaten by the mob. Pictures of the burning bus served to add impetus to the civil rights movement.

"I have a dream"

On being publicly pressured by King, President Kennedy made a decisive move. On June 11, 1963, he broadcast the urgent moral case for legislation to end segregation, saying, "This nation was founded on the principle that all men are created equal" and "Race has no place in American life and law."

In August, to put pressure on Congress to pass Kennedy's legislation, King led a march of 250,000 in Washington, DC, where he delivered his famous "I have a dream" speech and promised "an oasis of freedom and justice."

The March on Washington for Jobs and Freedom, led by Martin Luther King Jr., was held in August 1963. Some 250,000 people took part in this huge civil rights protest.

Kennedy was assassinated 3 months later, before his legislation had passed through all its stages. However, his successor, President Lyndon B. Johnson, using the tide of emotion from Kennedy's death, was able to push the Civil Rights Act through, and it became law in July 1964.

The new law guaranteed equal employment rights for all, outlawing discrimination in any business exceeding 25 people, and an Equal Employment Opportunity Commission was created to review complaints. The Act also protected black people against discrimination in voter qualification tests and outlawed segregation in hotels,

motels, restaurants, theaters, and all other public places. Additionally, desegregation in public schools was enforced, and federal funds would be withdrawn from any programs that practiced discrimination.

A key battle had been won in the fight against discrimination, but the long war continues. Martin Luther King Jr. was assassinated in Memphis, Tennessee, in 1968, aged 39, sparking a wave of race riots. Gradually, things improved for black people, and with the election of Barack Obama as president in 2009, it looked as if a corner might have been turned. However, it is clear that there is still a long way to go before true equality is achieved. ■

Martin Luther King Jr. gave his emotional, historic "I have a dream" speech to the assembled crowds at the Lincoln Memorial during the March on Washington, 1963.

